I've lost count of the times I've heard people around the game exclaim, 'God, he's so talented!' Sometimes that expression is tinged with exasperation. On other occasions, such as in the case of Joe Root, it reflects the emergence of a special player. He announced himself in the final Test of that Indian tour, at Nagpur.

I knew, instantly, that he was made for international cricket. He's naturally cheeky, and walked to the wicket for his first innings with a broad, beaming smile. He wasn't going to be overawed by the occasion. We probably should have selected him sooner, but that transitional stage, being exposed to the environment in training, held him in good stead.

I benefited similarly at the start of my career as an unused squad member in Pakistan. His inner belief, bolstered by the knowledge he had been picked as a fantastic player of spin, manifested itself in a first-innings 73. It came as a surprise when he offered a return catch to Piyush Chawla because he was so obviously comfortable.

The most improbable highlight of a drawn three-match series in New Zealand in the spring of 2013 was provided by Steve Finn, who erected the Watford Wall on the fifth day of the first Test in Dunedin. He had come in as night watchman the previous evening, when I was out after sharing a first-wicket partnership of 231 with Nick Compton, who also scored a hundred.

Since the match remained in the balance, an unorthodox approach was required. Quite simply, I 'incentivised' Finny. It began before the start of play with the promise that I would pay for his evening meal if he survived the first hour and ended just before tea with me ordering him a case of wine for making 56 and, more importantly, eking out 203 deliveries in 286 minutes at the crease. Had he reached a century I would have been in real trouble.

We warmed up for the Ashes in the return series against the Kiwis, winning both Test matches. Rooty scored his maiden Test hundred at Headingley, where I contributed 130 in the second innings and Graeme Swann took ten wickets. The sense of anticipation was tangible; unfortunately for Compo it was too much. He just went, mentally.

Promoting Joe to open in his place was the only major selection decision. The pundits, who have the privilege of not having to back up such statements, forecast victory as a formality. Beefy Botham, never one to